



Destroyer at sea

The USS *Maddox* DD-731 was a 2,235-ton, 376-ft (115 m) destroyer that had served in Korea and World War II. It was attacked by 66-ft (20 m) T4 PT boats, each armed with two torpedo tubes.

Swift retaliation

Johnson lost no time in declaring that the two destroyers had been subjected to unprovoked attacks. He sanctioned retaliatory air strikes on four North Vietnamese patrol boat bases and a major oil storage depot. Operation Pierce Arrow, as it was codenamed, sunk eight North Vietnamese PT boats and severely damaged 21 more. Two US aircraft were shot down; the pilot of one of them, Lieutenant Everett Alvarez Jr., became the first US airman taken as a prisoner of war by North Vietnam.

“Our **destroyers** were just shooting at **phantom targets** —there were **no PT boats.**”

SQUADRON COMMANDER JAMES STOCKDALE, IN THE *CHICAGO TRIBUNE*, 1990

Tonkin Gulf Resolution

On August 5, a special session of the Senate debated the Tonkin Gulf Resolution, giving Johnson the authority to “take all necessary measures, including the use of armed force” against any aggressor. It took less than two hours to pass the resolution, with only two senators, Ernest Gruening (D-Alaska) and Wayne Morse (D-Oregon), voting against. The House of Representatives passed it unanimously.

The allegation that the North Vietnamese had attacked the destroyers a second time was less convincing upon closer examination. Herrick, for one, was unsure whether any such attack had taken place. He later said that neither destroyer had made any “actual visual sightings” of PT boats. Commander James Stockdale, who led the jets from the *Ticonderoga*, was certain that no North Vietnamese vessels had been present. Such doubts were discounted by Johnson and his advisers, even though the president privately seemed to share them, postulating that the sailors had seen not torpedoes, but flying fish. His doubts